

When I left the office I felt like a free man for the first time in twelve years. For the next few days I was euphoric, tingling with pleasure. Then one Friday night about two weeks after I resigned, Vicki and I went to a dinner party with a group of friends. The men there were executives I had known for years, and we toasted my retirement. But the champagne didn't sit right. Halfway through dinner I lost my appetite. By the time the others had finished I felt nauseated. During dessert I asked Vicki to take me home.

I spent most of the night vomiting. At one point I asked Vicki to take me to the hospital. She resisted, telling me to try to sleep. The next day, Saturday, I couldn't keep down any solid food. I went to see a gastroenterologist.

"Have you been under any extraordinary stress lately?" he asked after I told him my symptoms.

I gritted my teeth and spit out a simple "yes." I'm sure my eyes told him how much I meant it. Thank God he didn't ask me to go into detail.

"I think you've got an ulcer," he told me. "Either that or a very nervous stomach related to the stress you're going through. I want you to go get an X-ray on Monday."

The X-ray showed nothing, and by Tuesday I was back to normal. The whole incident had been stress-related, a purely psychosomatic response to kicking the work habit.

My fleeting stomach problem was a small price to pay for my entry into the new world. Vicki and I have been happier in retirement than we ever thought possible, better than planned or hoped. I heartily recommend it. But don't kid yourself. Unless you're Superman, kicking the work habit may be one of the most agonizing moves you'll ever have to make. Only the tremendous opportunity of the new life makes it worthwhile.

Retirement isn't the only way out of executive crisis. You can arrange a long-term leave of absence. You can try changing jobs. You can pour yourself into fund-raising, a Little